

Passages - Practical Ethics

The famous Marxist slogan: 'From each according to his ability, to each according to his needs.' If this could be achieved the differences between the races and sexes would lose their social significance.

In the absence of positive evidence of discrimination against blacks, it is not possible to justify reverse discrimination on the grounds that it merely redresses the balance of discrimination existing in the community.

Adjusting test scores on this basis would not mean admitting black students in preference to better-qualified white students. It would reflect a decision that the disadvantaged students really were better qualified than the whites. This is not racial discrimination.

So if this same university should adopt new goals and use reverse discrimination to promote them, applicants who would have been admitted under the old procedure cannot claim that the new procedure violates their right to be admitted, or treats them with less respect than others. They had no special claim to be admitted in the first place; they were the fortunate beneficiaries of the old university policy. Now that this policy has changed others benefit, not they. If this seems unfair, it is only because we had become accustomed to the old policy.

severe inequality between races means a divided community with consequent racial tension.

If a being suffers, there can be no moral justification for refusing to take that suffering into consideration.

The overwhelming weight of medical evidence indicates that animal flesh is not necessary for good health or longevity. Nor is it an efficient way of producing food, since most of the animals consumed in industrialized societies have been fattened on grains and other foods which we could have eaten directly. When we feed these grains to animals, only about 10% of the nutritional value remains as meat for human consumption. So, with the exception of animals raised entirely on grazing land unsuitable for crops, animals are eaten neither for health, nor to increase our food supply. Their flesh is a luxury, consumed because people like its taste.

Experimenters often seek to justify experimenting on animals by claiming that the experiments lead us to discoveries about humans; if this is so, the experimenter must agree that human and nonhuman animals are similar in crucial respects.

One of the advantages of being a 'reasonable creature' is that one can find a reason for whatever one wants to do.

You cannot evade responsibility by imitating beings who are incapable of making this choice.

We need to know the natural laws which affect us in order to estimate the consequences of what we do; but we do not have to assume that the natural way of doing something is incapable of improvement.

If the basis of ethics is that I refrain from doing nasty things to others as long as

they don't do nasty things to me, I have no reason against doing nasty things to those who are incapable of appreciating my restraint and controlling their conduct towards me accordingly.

The behaviour of a fish on a hook suggests a reason for not killing fish by that method, but does not suggest a preference utilitarian reason against killing fish by a humane method.

Looking at things ethically is a way of transcending our inward-looking concerns and identifying ourselves with the most objective point of view possible - with, as Sidgwick put it, 'the point of view of the universe'.

If our life has no meaning other than our own happiness, we are likely to find that when we have obtained what we think we need to be happy, happiness itself still eludes us.

There is support to be found here for Thomas Nagel's account of imprudence as rational only if one fails to see oneself as a person existing over time, with the present merely one among other times one will live through. (Certainly psychopathic people live largely in the present and lack any coherent life plan.)

Our notion of ethics has become misleading to the extent that moral worth is attributed only to action done because it is right, without any ulterior motive. It is understandable, and from the point of view of society desirable, that this attitude should prevail; nevertheless, those who accept this view of ethics, and are led by it to do what is right because it is right, without asking for any further reason, are

falling victim to a kind of confidence trick - though not, of course, a consciously perpetrated one.